A SUMMARY OF THE ENTIRE HILCHOT SHABBAT IN 14 CLASSES

Cutting and Colouring: Gozez and Sovea

Class 8 of 14

Series: Laws of Shabbat — a 14-part course

Shiur: 8 of 14 — the start of Part 2 of the course

Topic: Gozez (Cutting) and Sove'a (Colouring) — hair, nails, make-up, sunbathing

Recorded: Tiferet Eyal, Hendon — 15 January 2019

Schedule note: Melaben (cleaning), planned for tonight, was moved to the next shiur.

Recap

Part 1 covered preparing for Shabbat, the kitchen melachot (cooking, threshing, selecting, grinding, kneading) and ploughing, planting and harvesting. Part 2 opens with cutting and colouring.

Part A — Gozez (Cutting)

Definition

In the Mishkan, the lowest roof covering was woven from four-ply thread — three strands of wool and one of linen — and the wool came from **shearing sheep**. Its derivatives are very common: cutting **hair**, **nails**, peeling **skin** around the nails, removing a **wart**. Gozez = removing any **appendage** of the body. (Cutting a limb is not Gozez — that is the body itself.)

Combing and brushing hair

Combing isn't cutting — but it is a **pesik reisha**: an inevitable result is forbidden even if unintended (the Gemara's case: cutting off a chicken's head to give a child a toy — you can't claim you didn't intend to kill it). A brush with **strong, thick bristles** will inevitably pull out at least one hair — and even **one hair** is forbidden. So:

- A hard, thick-bristled brush — **forbidden** (it shouldn't even be used on Shabbat).
- A brush with **soft bristles on a spongy base** — the bristles bend under pressure, so pulling hair is not inevitable; a hair that does come out is unintended and permitted.
- Even so, brush **moderately** — to look neat and respectable, not a vigorous, thorough brushing.
- Ashkenazi custom: a special brush reserved for Shabbat. Sephardim need not — the weekday brush is fine if soft.

Plaiting hair; wigs

- **Plaiting** hair is rabbinically forbidden as a form of **building**: the Torah says Hashem "built" Chava, and the Gemara says He braided her hair before bringing her to Adam. **Undoing** a plait is likewise forbidden (demolishing).

- Plaiting a **wig** is not building (the hair is detached) but is rabbinically forbidden as **weaving** (*oreg*).
- **Combing a wig** is permitted — the hair is already detached — unless the hair is badly matted (a Makeh Be'Patish issue).

Nails

Cutting nails is Gozez. **A woman due at the mikveh on Friday night who forgot to cut her nails:** the halacha is that she may ask a **non-Jew** to cut them. This rests on a recurring principle — **shevut deshevut bimkom mitzvah**: something twice removed from a Torah prohibition is permitted for a mitzvah.

1. Asking a non-Jew is itself only rabbinic.
2. Cutting nails one doesn't intend to use is, according to many, only rabbinic — *melacha she'einah tzrichah legufah* (in the Mishkan the wool was cut to be used).

A non-Jew may likewise **comb her hair** for the mikveh: a *pesik reisha* through a non-Jew is permitted. (Similarly, a non-Jew may open a fridge whose light will inevitably go on.) Q: Can she cut them herself with her teeth or hands? — The ruling is to ask a non-Jew.

A partly detached nail

Permitted to remove when all three conditions are met:

1. It is **painful** or bothering you considerably.
2. The **majority** of it is already detached (no longer "attached" in Torah terms).
3. You remove it with your **hand or teeth** (a shinui) — not a nail clipper.

Alternatively, ask a non-Jew to use clippers. **Q: what if someone normally bites their nails?** — We follow how most people do things, and most cut their nails with clippers.

Skin on the lips: be very careful not to pull it off with your teeth — that may be the *normal* way to do it, and the Mishnah Berurah suggests it could even be a Torah prohibition.

Part B — Sove'a (Colouring and Dyeing)

Definition

The threads of the Mishkan's covering were dyed blue, purple and scarlet — so dyeing is a Torah melacha. It includes **enhancing an existing colour**, not only changing it: repainting a white wall white, or **polishing black shoes** (one reason shoe polish is forbidden). Creating a picture is not dyeing but **writing** (Kotev).

Food and drink — *ein tzevi'ah be'ochlin*

- Combining foods that happen to change colour — fine by all.
- Even mixing foods **to create a colour** — e.g. jam into a toddler's white yoghurt to make it pink and appetising — is **permitted**: there is no dyeing with food, which is transient (and food wasn't dyed in the Mishkan). Accepted by Sephardim and most Ashkenazim.
- Only for **eating or drinking**. Colouring food for business display, or colouring water as an ornament — forbidden by the Torah.
- **Food colouring** may be used (Q from the floor) — it is colouring food.
- Some (Ashkenazi stringency) reverse the usual order — e.g. cordial/syrup first, then water. Good to do, but strictly it is permitted.

Blood and stains on cloth

Wrapping a bleeding finger in a towel, or wiping red strawberry or pomegranate juice off your hands onto a towel, inevitably "dyes" it — but it is a *pesik reisha* of a destructive act you get no benefit from (*pesik reisha delo nicha lei* in a rabbinic matter), so it is **permitted**. The poskim add: if a tap is nearby, rinse first. A cut finger isn't an emergency — but there's no need to delay dressing a wound.

Make-up

- Make-up on the skin is not permanent, so it is **rabbinic** — but all regular make-up and lipstick are forbidden.
- Regular make-up is oil- or cream-based and adheres to the skin. **Pure powder** — no oil or cream — merely sits on the surface and is very transient. Most poskim — **Chacham Ovadia, Rav Moshe Feinstein** — permit it ("Shabbat make-up"); Rav Shlomo Zalman Auerbach was not happy with it.
- Apply it only to a **clean face**, not over cream-based make-up from before Shabbat (which would rub the powder in).
- **Removing** make-up is permitted.

Sunbathing to tan

Not a walk on a hot day — but deliberately sitting on a balcony for hours to tan. The room was split. The point: you are not *doing* anything; the sun acts on you — **gerama** (indirect).

- A handful of poskim forbid it: dyeing is inherently a gradual process (like leaving cloth in a dye vat), just as cooking in an oven isn't "indirect".
- **The majority (Chacham Ovadia among them) permit sunbathing even with intent to tan.**
- But not if it becomes **uncomfortable** — sitting in discomfort just to show off a tan contradicts *oneg Shabbat*. And consider the spirit of Shabbat: half an hour reading in the sun, yes; a whole afternoon soaking up rays, no.
- For vitamin D: what **ordinary people do** for enjoyment isn't forbidden as "medicine" (like prune juice for mild constipation), so it is permitted even for health.

Toilet colouring blocks

- A block in the **cistern** — permitted by all: the new water is coloured only as it refills, an inevitable but indirect result (*pesik reisha be'gerama*) — like pouring water onto concrete that trickles onto grass.
- A block **in the bowl** — flushing sends water straight through it. Debated: some call flushing indirect (you only lift a valve and gravity does the rest), or say the colour is too transient. Remove it before Shabbat if you can; if you find one at someone's home, there is plenty to rely on to use the toilet.

Q: forming shapes (with food) — a Kotev (writing) question, to be discussed later.

Summary

- **Gozez:** no cutting hair, nails or skin. Only a soft, sponge-based brush, used moderately. No plaiting hair or wigs; combing a wig is fine.
- For the mikveh, a **non-Jew** may cut a woman's nails and comb her hair. A painful, mostly-detached nail may be removed by hand or teeth. Don't bite skin off your lips.
- **Sove'a:** no dyeing or enhancing colour (shoe polish). No dyeing with food and drink — colouring for eating is fine. Wiping blood or juice on a towel is permitted.

- Regular make-up forbidden; pure powder on a clean face permitted by most. Sunbathing permitted in moderation and comfort. Cistern toilet blocks are fine; remove in-bowl ones before Shabbat if possible.

Coming Up

Shiur 9 — 22 January:

- **Melaben** (cleaning) — stains on a suit, laundering, cleaning dust off clothes
- **Knots** — tying shoelaces, tying up the dustbin
- **Animals** — trapping and hunting; pets

B'Ezrat Hashem

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